



Xulc Expansion

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Prologue

Infection

It's been just over a couple of weeks since Lalos was changed forever. Both the continent and its people were waking up to a virgin world. In the north, the Keb Rasska clans once enslaved by the Ezmen Queens forge new freedoms from their psychic grasp. Travelling down to the heart of Lalos, the Uzem is relieved of their pains, and the King of Storms is no longer an epithet to be feared. West to the Unsouled Barrens, Bazhar's twisted plans are thwarted, and to the southeast, the tifhur of the Taharik move within their newly uncorrupted swampland after the quelling of the Ahma. All crowned by the earth shaking collapse of Era to the ground and the ruin of The Eclipse, where the starlings now dutifully rebuild their homeland.

You've been resting in Tuor at Silky's behest, recuperating and enjoying the best of zusag dining and entertainment. The Fundamentalist has been somewhat of an absent host of late, mostly reading scrolls and missives in his study, quick to dismiss any interruption. Maybe this is just what he's like when he's not trying to save Lalos? Ether knows he's probably behind on his administrative duties at least. Last week you said goodbye to Mo and Makaal, who excitedly set off on Grandpaw back to Makaal's clan in the Thunder Mesa, ready to make "honestly unbelievable profits", as Makaal put it. As you reach a point where you agree to go your separate ways back to the independent call of the Rover, Silky calls for a meeting. Maybe you do get a goodbye after all.

"My wondrous warriors, my salubrious saviors, my remarkable Rovers. How have you enjoyed the best Tuor has to offer?" Silky chirps, beckoning all to take a seat. You've travelled long enough with the elder zusag to know not to attempt to answer what is clearly a pleasantry prior to his more important sentiment. A moment of silence hangs in the air. You look at each other - perhaps he is actually awaiting a response. Clearing your throat to answer, Silky interjects;

"Wonderful, wonderful. Now, my rovers, doesn't this feel familiar? Us all together like this again. Familiarity is a strange thing, isn't it. A strange thing, that both soothes

and blinds. To engage with the familiar too much is to dull one's senses, you see!" He taps his antlers for effect. "But, we can allow ourselves a little luxury and comfort can't we? We relieved the land of innumerable dangers, in the way only a band of Rovers can!" The most familiar thing here is the desire to see the Zusag get to the point. "So, Rovers, I come to you with the gift of familiarity. I have a quest for you!" You all look at each other with a mix of bewilderment and pity. The poor old zusag really doesn't want to let us go, does he?

"Now I know what you're thinking, what quest could possibly warrant a band of Rovers again? Well, my curious companions, my dear dynamos, I have been receiving missives from my associates in the Unsouled Barrens. Unusual notes of theran activity acting wild, and I thought perhaps this is some consequence of Bazhar's defeat by your hands, or even an attempt at resurgence. Since you'll all be going down south together as you part ways, why not make sure we finish the job we started, ey? And I'll accompany you once more! In person this time. It'll be just like 'old times' as the youth say." Painfully aware that the 'old times' were mere weeks ago, you reluctantly shrug. One of the last places you would like to visit again is the Unsouled Barrens, but perhaps Silky is right - it's not worth the risk of Bazhar's resurgence.

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Starting the Xulc Campaign

The Xulc campaign is a level 9 adventure. **You should only play this campaign if you have completed the core box Rove campaign.** You play your level 9 Rovers from the core box campaign or create new level 9 Rovers, following the quick level guide in the core rulebook on page 63.

You'll come across several new rules while playing this campaign. These new rules will be introduced within the encounters of the campaign.

Keep your core box campaign sheet nearby while playing the Xulc campaign. Several of the encounters will reference the core box campaign sheet and its milestones.

On your Xulc campaign sheet, under Adversary Ether Fields, mark  and . For this campaign, you will use these values for adversary aura and miasma tiles.

Open up quest box XU-1 and unpack the standees. These standees will be used for Encounters 10.1 through 10.5.

Mo and Makaal

Mo and Makaal are living their best lives in Carmizon Reach, making a killing selling all the lyst and material they gained while adventuring with you during the Star Hunter raids. Since they are no longer around, their shop is closed and you can't buy items.

If you choose to create new Rovers for this campaign, each new Rovers gains 300 lyst. Spend this lyst on equipment and small items. Once you have equipped your new Rovers, the shop is once again closed.

Campaign Link



Go to Encounter 1 - “The Nameless Black of a Name”,  4.

The Nameless Black of a Name

Introduction

Transcribed musings from “Silky”, resident Fundamentalist of the Mist clan.

Peace... peace my prized pupils is the ghost of hope. It is an echo in a bottle, a sculpture of Crux. Peace is a thought that holds such weight, such promise, but by definition dies the moment it is recognised for what it is. Peace is the absence of life, it is the denial of potential. Peace is inert, sterile, it leaves no space for hurt, yearning, hunger. It leaves no space for evolution. And even then, dear disciple, those passing times where peace is felt, how long does it last? Does not the larval galeaper feel peace when it escapes the hungry briarbull, only then to fear the lurching, searching tendrils of the urn? Does not the craftsman feel peace as he finishes a project, only to be demanded to return to the lathe by necessity or ingenuity? No, peace is a terrible thing to spend much time striving for, a whisper to the wind. And even the most morphean of morphics knows Chorus’s everchanging song leaves little room for whispers.

It feels strange to be travelling together again after all you’ve been through. No sibling-like banter between Mo and Makaal, no rumbling vibrato from Grandpaw’s comforting grumble. No falling sky to avert or despotic warlords to thwart. Silky and his Aerios do their best to fill the notable silence with verbose pontification and impressive aerial gymnastics respectively, but strange it still feels. It reminds you of when you first came together at Silky’s request, a time of curiosity and the unknown. In many ways you are unrecognisable as the Rovers you were then, now apexes of your kind, carrying scars and wisdom in abundance. However there is a certain resonance with the experience you had all that time ago, and in that resonance you feel youthful again. It feels strange to be travelling together after all you’ve been through. But it does feel kind of nice. That is, until you remember where you’re going.

The Unsouled Barrens remain as nightmarish as the last time you visited. The stagnant pressure in the air, the tingle of your fight or flight response as if the ground

beneath you was waiting for the perfect moment to swallow you whole. Though the wasteland has receded, it still feels like predatory oblivion. “I truly would have thought this place would be smaller by now.” Silky states, an unusual edge in his voice. “But we’re nearly where my report identified as the hub of activity.” With a luminous gesture of his claws, Silky’s Aerios soars onward, beyond the large column of jagged rock blocking your eventual path. The wet gnashing of broken teeth and slick licks of pseudopods heralded the all too familiar presence of stomaw ahead, but turning the corner directly reveals an unexpected scene. The stomaw and urns here appear... sick. Not the kind of sickness spawned by Bazhar’s foul fleshcraft, something far... stranger. A rotten pang of pestilence covers the tongues of those among you who have them, and the therans themselves appear uneasy, nauseous and aimless. “What in the five schools...” utters Silky, the buoyant lilt in his voice gone. The sickness here is unlike any you’ve seen in all of your roving. It’s best to put these creatures out of their misery, lest the infection spread.

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Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 3 ▶ Go to 2.

Tiles: 2x Hatchery

Victory Condition



Slay all adversaries.

Round limit: 8 ⌚

Challenges



- 1 When rolling the damage dice for adversary attacks, increase the result of by +1 ⚡.
- 2 When rolling the xulc dice, reroll any results of a blank face.
- 3 Xulc are immune to the effects of ether fields.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter a jagged bones space suffer ⚡ 2.



Units that trigger Hatchery traps suffer ⚡ 4.



Difficult terrain is water.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1 ⚡ to the first attack they perform during their turn.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain -1 ⚡ to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Codex Links



Q1

Immediately after the action where the first stomaw or an urn are slain, read “Kill it With Fire!” 2.

Intermission
Strange Days

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Introduction

The blur of action that followed your encounter with the xulc is hard to recall. Informed by some bizarre somatic alchemy of fear, base survival instinct and your new body-buddy's attempt to show you what it could offer - if only you would submit to me - you are thrust into this new, frightening moment. You can't even remember who carried Silky's exhausted body but he lies now before you in a tent, at your campsite, far from the Unsouled Barrens. Who lit the fire? Who hunted and skinned the beast that now spins above it, flesh sizzling? What beast is it? These are all questions you wish to ask each other, but the absence of anyone speaking up demonstrates simply that none of you know more than the other. The pregnant silence is interrupted by Silky's weakened voice. "This is why I leave the roving to the professionals".

The old zusag's fur appears dull and weak, but the soul in his eyes is as bright as ever - at least what you can see of them beneath his pained squinting. This is reassuring.

"In all of my pursuits both scholarly and spiritual, never have I seen something so... antagonistic to crux. Not devoid of it, nor neglectful of it in favor of the other Major Anima or Minor Arcana... but repellant of it. I'm afraid to say dear friends that it shook me to my very core." He pulls himself up and looks at each of you. A flicker of uncertainty crosses his face, yet he decides not to acknowledge it. "Now, this infestation appears dangerous. Unpredictable. And if my reports are consistent, it's something that is spreading fast and has been able to take hold quicker than any other swarm infestation I've heard of."

I'm afraid I must return back home to Tuor and recover, whilst I reconnect with my Eyes and Ears, and consult my fellow Fundamentalists. As powerful as you have become, my resplendent rovers, I recommend recruitment and reconnection to rout this rot before it ravages all."

"One of my first reports of this strange blight came from a band of querists in the Barrens, and have reported many a scuffle with strange-acting stomaw. Young and resourceful as they may be, the young associates need your help if the parasites within have emerged in the same manner as those we saw today."

"Elsewhere, I feel this threat may take some investment to investigate with intent. Perhaps your old travelling companions Mo and Makaal would be valuable to check in on, given their penchant for providing readily available resources at premium prices. Chorus knows

you'll likely be in need of a powdered drakaen or two. Last I heard they had returned to Makaal's clan to the south, in the Thunder Mesa."

"Finally, I'm sure you noticed as I did that these parasites seemed utterly devoid of affinity with ether. Logic would dictate then that starlings, being constituted of ether as they are, may hold unique power in being able to fight them. I wonder if that magnificent mountain mite Hra would be willing to help us, or perhaps could point us in the direction of another that could."

"By the time you have followed up these leads, I should be well recovered, and may know more about the scope and scale of this scourge." Silky carves a glyph out of thin air and glowing motes of light flicker into being around his tired legs, framing them in a pseudo-cast. Stealing another quick glance at each other, it's clear the same thought passes through each of your minds; probably best not to mention the xulc within you until you know a little more - **and then you'll share our gifts and be united as one forever bound in togetherness you feel it don't you it's beautiful it's strong it's - enough.**

Onwards.

Choice



- A** This infestation is taking hold quickly. There is a stomaw nest to the west that needs your attention:

Encounter 2 - "**Nidifugous by Nature**",  8.

- B** You could use Mo and Makaal's assistance. Head to Carmizon Reach and see how they are doing:

Encounter 3 - "**Keen Debtors**",  16.

- C** Xulc appear to lack an affinity with ether, making starlings uniquely suited to fight them. There's someone you think can help you fight the infestation:

Encounter 4 - "**Ought Never to Sprout**",  20.

Nidifugous by Nature

Introduction

Gargaki slithered up Ozendyn's leg and onto his chest, letting out a low gargled pur of comfort. Ozeyndyn' looked down at the coruscopod and grunted. "Leave it alone will you. I do not need your sympathies." The old warrior's companion animal let out a defiant sound as it trailed back down next to its master's rollbed in a huff. The corsucopod had spent many an evening attempting to comfort its master since the collapse of the bonespire, but Ozendyn refused to allow himself the respite. Not because it wasn't wanted, but because it was awfully unfamiliar. After Bazhar's destruction, Ozendyn was no longer the last, defiant warrior of his clan. The last remaining Sentinel of the Wake. No, he was just Ozendyn, a warrior with no war. A sentinel with no charge. He was just a man, now, and few fates are less reassuring.

A familiar snicker echoed beyond the light of Ozendyn's campfire. "By my father's blade, won't you give it a rest?!" the man shouted into the darkness. "Nobody's here!" answered the voice of a young zusag, followed immediately by a smattering of giggles from similar voices. "Then with whom do I bicker, night after night?" Ozendyn replied tiredly. "The wind!" a second zusag answered. "Yeah, from your backside!" offered a third. All around Ozendyn, the youthful sneering of the balatronists following him smothered the quiet night in laughter. Whether from exhaustion or boredom, Ozendyn found the corner of his lip turning upwards. "Just a man", he thought. "But not alone."

Following Silky's guidance you search for a small warren to the east of your campsite. It takes the better part of an afternoon, a trip mostly undertaken in pensive silence as your throbbing xulc-wound pangs. You feel the beckoning voice of the parasite in the back of your mind, and you know your allies feel the same. It is not synchronised, no - the xulc 'voices' do not speak in unison. Each of you are fighting your own individual battle with an individual parasite, hoping you individually can survive its biological onslaught long enough to find a way to kill it.

You are happy for the tension to be broken by the familiar rotten pang of pestilence, a scent of iron, dirt, and meat. A call to action. Following the source of the stench to a nearby stomaw nest, you see yet another unexpected and unwelcome sight. A tall, hulking humanoid festooned in vibrant green eggsacs, swinging a simple club lazily at an ensemble of zusag. The eggs on its back pulsate and quiver, birthing slime-covered xulc that fall helplessly into the water below, then springing into violent life.

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 4 ▶ Go to 4.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps, 3x Hoards

Victory Condition



Slay the Nidus.

Round limit: 10

Challenges



- 1 The Nidus gains +5*R .
- 2 Each time a Rover deals 3 or more with an attack, they drain an ether dice in their personal pool, if able to.
- 3 When an effect of the Nidus would have you roll the xulc dice, reroll any results of a blank face.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter a jagged bones space suffer 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



It costs units 1 additional movement point to enter a space within 1 of this object.



Units within 1 of this object gain -1 to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Balatronists

Check your core box campaign sheet, If you have either milestone “**Encountered the Balatronists**” or “**Rescued 3 Querists**” marked, read the following:

The zusag before you are familiar - they are the querists that bothered you when you were last in the Unsouled Barrens! It appears Silky, in all his sneaky wisdom, had kept tabs on the rebellious young associates all this time. At the centre of the querists is another, more welcome familiar face; Ozendyn and his pet coruscopod, Gargaki. The old warrior appears tired and bruised - it's clear that he has been fighting off this xulc-infested creature to defend the zusag, but had been brought low by its hulking form and the writhing stomaw around him. One of the querists notices you. “Rovers! It's the Rovers! Thank the Nose - Ozendyn, he needs your help!” You rush into battle as the zusag appear steeled by your presence, pushing through their fear to summon glyphs of pure crux to aid you.

Replace up to 3 pod traps with 3 reflective glyph traps. If an adversary triggers this trap, they suffer 3. If a Rover triggers this trap, they recover 3.



Nidifugous by Nature

Otherwise:

The zusag are youthful - querists, the rebellious sort who go out to seek adventure in the world beyond their clans. They are frightened, wielding polearms not as weapons but as a tree does its branch in a storm - flailing stiffly, awkwardly, under pressure. In the centre is the old warrior you know from this place known as Ozendyn, that final warrior who would chop down the bonespire with his sword alone if he thought he'd live long enough to see it done. The warrior lies bloodied, but his companion coruscopod Gargaki recognizes you and rushes to your aid with a slithering, hungry pur.

One Rover gains the following passive benefit for this encounter:

Gargaki: When a writhing stomaw is slain, perform:



Codex Links



4

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “What was Lost”,  3.

5

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “What Once Was”,  3.

6

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “What Will Never Be”,  3.

7

Immediately when the Nidus is slain, read “It Bursts with a Nervous Little Pop!”,  4.

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Nidifugous by Nature

Introduction

Gargaki slithered up Ozendyn's leg and onto his chest, letting out a low gargled pur of comfort. Ozeyndyn' looked down at the coruscopod and grunted. "Leave it alone will you. I do not need your sympathies." The old warrior's companion animal let out a defiant sound as it trailed back down next to its master's rollbed in a huff. The corsucopod had spent many an evening attempting to comfort its master since the collapse of the bonespire, but Ozendyn refused to allow himself the respite. Not because it wasn't wanted, but because it was awfully unfamiliar. After Bazhar's destruction, Ozendyn was no longer the last, defiant warrior of his clan. The last remaining Sentinel of the Wake. No, he was just Ozendyn, a warrior with no war. A sentinel with no charge. He was just a man, now, and few fates are less reassuring.

A familiar snicker echoed beyond the light of Ozendyn's campfire. "By my father's blade, won't you give it a rest?!" the man shouted into the darkness. "Nobody's here!" answered the voice of a young zusag, followed immediately by a smattering of giggles from similar voices. "Then with whom do I bicker, night after night?" Ozendyn replied tiredly. "The wind!" a second zusag answered. "Yeah, from your backside!" offered a third. All around Ozendyn, the youthful sneering of the balatronists following him smothered the quiet night in laughter. Whether from exhaustion or boredom, Ozendyn found the corner of his lip turning upwards. "Just a man", he thought. "But not alone."

You return to the area that you left Silky after that first encounter with the xulc, but how different things are now. It should feel better. You know it should. Mo and Makaal are with you, riding Grandpaw and bickering. The majestic form of Hra gently shakes the earth with each of their giant footsteps. You're a party again, a historic band of Rovers and their myriad allies. But it doesn't feel better. It feels more familiar, sure, but that feeling of familiarity is sabotaged by the throbbing of your xulc-wound. You feel the beckoning voice of the parasite in the back of your mind, and you know your fellow Rovers feel

the same. It is not synchronised, no - the xulc 'voices' do not speak in unison. Each of you are fighting your own individual battle with an individual parasite, hoping you individually can survive its biological onslaught long enough to find a way to kill it. Following Silky's initial directions to his band of zusag informants, you hear the screams of combat and clashes of steel on the horizon. An unimaginable stench radiates with such thickness, such airborne viscosity that it's as if you're underwater in a sea of pure fecundity. Before you is a stomaw nest - or at least what was one, however in its place is a living mound of bulbous, steaming flesh. A pillar of fat bubbles like boiling oil, peaked by what appears to be the metastasized torso of a humanoid, facial features rendered neutral by silvered grey folds of growth. Its entire body - if you can stretch that word's definition enough to call it that - is rotten with vibrant green eggsacs.

All across this mound, these eggs roil and pulsate and quiver, birthing slime-covered xulc that fall helplessly into the water below, then spring into violent life. Around this - glorious profound advancement - is a band of zusag fending off the swarm of xulc and mutated stomaw.

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 5 ▶ Go to 5.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps, 3x Hoards

Victory Condition



Slay the Nidus Cluster.

Round limit: 10

Challenges



- 1 **Nidus Cluster** triggers during the **Start Phase** of rounds 2, 4, 6, 8, and 10.
- 2 Each time a Rover deals 3 or more with an attack, they drain an ether dice in their personal pool, if able to.
- 3 When an effect of the Nidus would have you roll the xulc dice, reroll any results of a blank face.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter a jagged bones space suffer 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



It costs units 1 additional movement point to enter a space within 1 of this object.



Units within 1 of this object gain -1 to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Balatronists

Check your core box campaign sheet. If you have either milestone “**Encountered the Balatronists**” or “**Rescued 3 Querists**” marked, read the following:

The wounded zusag are familiar - they are the querists that bothered you when you were last in the Unsouled Barrens! It appears Silky, in all his sneaky wisdom, had kept tabs on the rebellious young associates all this time. The querists appear to be safeguarding another, more welcome familiar face; Ozendyn and his pet coruscopod, Gargaki. The old warrior appears gravely wounded amidst a pile of dead xulc- it's clear that he has been fighting off this living altar to pestilence to defend the zusag, but had been brought low by its never-ending swarm. One of the querists notices you. “Rovers! It's the Rovers! Help! He's dying!!” You rush into battle as the zusag appear steeled by your presence, pushing through their fear to summon glyphs of pure crux to aid you.

Replace up to 3 pod traps with 3 reflective glyph traps. If an adversary triggers this trap, they suffer 3. If a Rover triggers this trap, they recover 3.

Otherwise:

The zusag are youthful - querists, the rebellious sort who go out to seek adventure in the world beyond their clans. This is far from the adventure that they would seek, this

Nidifugous by Nature

is terror, this is rot, this is abomination and inevitable death. In the centre is the old warrior you know from this place known as Ozendyn, that final warrior who would chop down the bonespire with his sword alone if he thought he'd live long enough to see it done. The warrior lies bloodied, exhausted, holding onto consciousness by the skin of his teeth. Ozendyn's companion coruscopod Gargaki recognizes you and rushes to you with a display of sheer terror, but determined to save its old friend.

One Rover gains the following passive benefit for this encounter:

Gargaki: When a writhing stomaw is slain, perform:



Nidus Cluster

The Nidus has metastasized into a nidus cluster.

Place the Nidus as seen on the map, on top of the monstrous growth tile. The Nidus and the tile are the same unit for this encounter. They can not be moved or teleported for any reason.

During the **Start Phase** of round 3, 6, and 9, Roll the Xulc dice R times and spawn the results within ⚡ 1 of the monstrous growth.

Codex Links

Q 4

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “**What was Lost**”,  3.

Q 5

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “**What Once Was**”,  3.

Q 6

If a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile , remove the tile and read “**What Will Never Be**”,  3.

Q 8

Immediately when the Nidus is slain, read “**Eruption**”,  5.



Act One • Encounter 3

Keen Debtors

Introduction

Makaal thumbed through the contents of the skarasilk pouch as the sun hung low in the sky. Wiping the sweat from his brow, he tossed the pocket of lyst into the basket with the others. “Another fine day’s work, Mo!”

The starling’s tendrils coiled tight around their head for a moment, before casting the tension away, as if to physically reset. “Who would have thought saving Lalos would have been so profitable?” Mo retorted with not-so-subtle lathering of sarcasm.

“Me, Mo. Like, actually me. We spoke about this. A lot, actually”. Makaal had been perfecting the formula to blunt Mo’s increasingly sardonic mien, and by the way Mo ignored him, he knew he was getting pretty good. The young merchant knew Mo’s walls wouldn’t hold for long, this conversational war of attrition would inevitably tilt into the favor of Makaal’s relentless siege of denial.

Grandpaw’s jaw stretched wide, a pungent exhalation of tired arkenyn-breath bristling the hairs of Makaal’s nose. It doesn’t matter how much he loves his companion, he rarely welcomes the scent. With a basket full of lyst and his clan hailing him a hero, Makaal hoped he’d find a greater peace in his heart after returning home, but he does wonder why his greatest pleasure at the moment is tormenting Mo, and why he simply doesn’t care to spend any of the lyst he’s accrued. Ah well, a problem to be cured by earning more lyst. Probably.

It’s always a strange sensation when you enter the Thunder Mesa. There are no signs, no real outposts, just the transition of mountainous stone to the soft crunch of sand, the rumble-drums of thunder in the distance and the metallic tongue tickle of ionized Air ether. Although the trek to this part of Lalos has been somewhat tainted by tension, anxiety and unexpected gifts to your bodies. Though the King of Storms is at peace, you remember that thunder and lightning need not a monarch to inspire awe and dread.

As you arrive at Carmizon Reach, you feel a blend of fondness and reservation about seeing your travelling

companions again. Though it’s been mere weeks, the world feels very different now. Arriving to the outskirts of Makaal’s clan, you are immediately recognized. The sentry rushes over to you with their arkenyn pup in tow. “Rovers! You’re the Rovers who helped Mo and Makaal save Lalos! I’d recognise you from their descriptions anywhere!”

Not quite how things played out, but you’re far too concerned with your unwelcome passengers to challenge the dewy-eyed sentry. “Are you looking for them? They’re not here right now, I’m afraid. They accompanied the ranger party on a supply run yesterday afternoon - the scouts feel much safer in the company of such powerful heroes as our own Mo and Makaal!” You’re pretty sure you see the sentry shed a tear as they say this. “That being said, they are unusually late. They should have returned this morning. But you’re welcome to wait! My husband would love to meet you, he’s a huge fan.”

Call it a trauma response, call it paranoia, call it a psionic resonance, but something about their delay sets you on edge. Asking for the directions that the ranger party took, you set off hopefully to meet them halfway.

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 6 ▶ Go to 6-7.

Tiles: 4x Magical Traps, 2x Pod Traps, 6x Hoards

Victory Condition



Survive for 7 rounds.

Round limit: 7

Loss Conditions



Lose if Mo and Makaal are slain.

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Challenges



- 1 When rolling an ether dice for **Mo and Makaal**, a result of  or  have no effect. No Rover is healed and no  is placed.
- 2 When a xulc is spawned, they immediately take a turn.
- 3 Rovers can not remove dice from ether nodes.

Terrain



Units that trigger a magic trap suffer  3. When a magic trap is triggered, roll an ether dice and place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll in the space the trap was in. A result of  or  places an adversary  or , respectively.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer  3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within  1 of this object recover  1.



Units within  1 of this object gain +1  to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Mo and Makaal

That same smell of infection hits you first as always. Bodies of rangers litter the floor, whilst a few warriors



remain, protecting Mo and Makaal as they pack wares onto the back of Grandpaw. You watch as Mo affixes the strap of a large leather bandolier whilst Makaal haphazardly hurls glass bottles and ointments at the infected savannah creatures, exploding in a rainbow of chemicals. All around are similarly infected urns, whilst it appears the xulc have also managed to find their way here. But how? So sudden, so soon? These are questions to answer once Mo and Makaal are safe.

Mo and Makaal are a part of the Rover faction.

Together they have 8 . During the **End Phase** each round they throw a potion. Roll an ether dice from the general pool, on a result of , , or , the most damaged Rover unit within  0-3 recovers  3. On a result of , , or , place one  within  1-3, closest to the nearest enemy.

Exploding Infestation

There are six ether icons on the edges of the map. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



9

Each time a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile, remove the tile and read “What Do We Have Here?”,  6.

2

Each time a stolen urn is slain, read “Riddled Shell”,  2.

10

At the end of round 7, read “We’re Leaving”,  6.

Keen Debtors

Introduction

Makaal thumbed through the contents of the skarasilk pouch as the sun hung low in the sky. Wiping the sweat from his brow, he tossed the pocket of lyst into the basket with the others. “Another fine day’s work, Mo!”

The starling’s tendrils coiled tight around their head for a moment, before casting the tension away, as if to physically reset. “Who would have thought saving Lalos would have been so profitable?” Mo retorted with not-so-subtle lathering of sarcasm.

“Me, Mo. Like, actually me. We spoke about this. A lot, actually”. Makaal had been perfecting the formula to blunt Mo’s increasingly sardonic mien, and by the way Mo ignored him, he knew he was getting pretty good. The young merchant knew Mo’s walls wouldn’t hold for long, this conversational war of attrition would inevitably tilt into the favor of Makaal’s relentless siege of denial.

Grandpaw’s jaw stretched wide, and a pungent exhalation of tired arkenyn-breath bristling the hairs of Makaal’s nose. It doesn’t matter how much he loved his companion, he rarely welcomes the scent. With a basket full of lyst and his clan hailing him a hero, Makaal hoped he’d find a greater peace in his heart after returning home, but he does wonder why his greatest pleasure at the moment is tormenting Mo, and why he simply doesn’t care to spend any of the lyst he’s accrued. Ah well, a problem to be cured by earning more lyst. Probably.

It’s always a strange sensation when you enter the Thunder Mesa. There are no signs, no real outposts, just the transition of mountainous stone to the soft crunch of sand, the rumble-drums of thunder in the distance and the metallic tongue tickle of ionized Air ether. You feel it more sensitively than before. The swelling power of the xulc gifts - infections in your bodies make the ether around you... sting. Not in a painful way, but as if you’d soaked your bodies in peppervine tea and plunged into icewater. It’s spicy. Hra provides some comfort, however; the monotony of their footsteps provide something of a marching beat to take your attention. Barely a word has

been spoken by the starling, but something about their large form, their seeding of plants and stone, provides you with reassurance. Like walking with the living shelter of your own personal mountain ~~foul beast~~ ~~foul creature~~ ~~won’t survive~~ ~~won’t~~ be needed ~~you don’t need them~~ ~~you have me~~ ~~you have us~~.

As you arrive at Carmizon Reach, you feel a blend of fondness and reservation about seeing your travelling companions again. Though it’s been mere weeks, the world feels very different now. Arriving to the outskirts of Makaal’s clan, you are immediately recognized. The sentry rushes over to you with their arkenyn pup in tow. “Rovers! You’re the Rovers who helped Mo and Makaal save Lalos! I’d recognise you from -” The sentry stops. The arkenyn lets out a low growl.

You can see the panic in their faces. “Are you... Are you well, Rovers?”

A quick dismissal of some bad camp food is all you need to push aside the sentries desire to learn more. The concern is still there, of course, but something in them knows better than to keep asking.

“I, I see. Are you looking for Mo and Makaal? They’re not here right now, I’m afraid. Missing, actually. They accompanied the ranger party on a supply run a few noons ago. They should have returned the following morning, but there’s been no sign of them. We were going to send a search party to look for them today, actually. Since you’re here, would you mind havi-” ~~your friends~~ ~~will be with us soon~~ ~~all will be together soon~~. The sentry need not finish their response.

Hra flutters their tendrils and moves grinding stone: “There. I sense it.”

You move.

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 7 ▶ Go to 6-7.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps, 2x Magical Traps, 1x Hoard

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Victory Condition



Survive for 7 rounds.

Round limit: 7 ⌚

Loss Conditions



Lose if Mo and Makaal are slain.

Challenges



- 1 Replace magic traps with pod traps.
- 2 When a xulc is spawned, they immediately take a turn.
- 3 Remove the ether dice from the ether nodes on the map.

Terrain



Units that trigger a magic trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a magic trap is triggered, roll an ether dice and place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll in the space the trap was in. A result of or places an adversary or , respectively.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within ↗ 1 of this object recover ❤️ 1.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1 ⚡ to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Mo and Makaal Wounded

That same smell of infection hits you first as always. Bodies of numerous rangers litter the floor, only two remaining. Makaal throws a potion of glowing blue oil at a monstrous infected bulwarous, watching it screech as it burns. Grandpaw launches himself at one head of a mindless dyad whilst Mo wields their whittling knife to stab the other. Makaal is bleeding. It looks like he might have broken an arm. Grandpaw's snowy coat is stained in red and black, blood from himself and the xulc alike. Makaal's ether looks thin and wispy. Thank the ether they're alive, but barely.

Mo and Makaal are a part of the Rover faction.

Together they have 8 ❤️. Mo and Makaal are injured and are doing everything they can to pack Grandpaw. They are unable to assist you during this fight.

Exploding Infestation

There are six ether icons on the edges of the map. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



Q9

Each time a Rover enters into a space with hoard tile, remove the tile and read “What Do We Have Here?”, 6.

Q2

Each time a stolen urn is slain, read “Riddled Shell”, 2.

Q11

At the end of round 7, read “The Road Yawns”, 7.

Ought Never to Sprout

Introduction

“Let’s not have a repeat of last night please, little ones.” Permea offered the warning gently as she pulled the blanket over her younger siblings, but the warning held no water. She knew how hard it was for them as it came upon the anniversary of their mother’s passing. She knew because she felt it too.

“Come on Perrrrm.” Olivon made sure to draw out his big sister’s name. “One more story.”

“Yeah! Come on Perrrrm” Mehandra echoed her twin.

Permea was tired. It had been a long day at the market, and all she wanted was her own space to rest and escape. Looking at the two babes, both barely 9 summers old, she heard her mother’s voice and agreed.

“Ok, my flowers. One more. Did mother ever tell you the story of the living mountain?”

The twins shook their heads in unison, bringing the blanket up to place it gently on their lips for comfort.

“One day, she was out Roving. A clan of tihfur reported a thunderous noise in the night that kept many of them up, and thinking it was the King of Storms, were afraid to investigate themselves.

Mother searched for the source of the noise until she found it; a hulking great starling of the most potent Earthen ether, stone and granite and mud and moss, stomping the ground in distress. They were a quadruped - that means they had four legs, like an arkenyn or a grovetender, with a taaaaaall neck like a galeaper.

‘Hello!’ mother shouted, ‘Are you ok? Do you need help?’ But you see, this starling wasn’t like others - it hadn’t grown amongst other folk and so didn’t really know what to make of it.”

Permea did her best low, grumbly voice. “‘Yes’, the starling responded. ‘Can you tell me why I’m here? What my purpose is?’

Now, mother had not a clue how to respond. ‘I’ll let you know when I figure that out for myself, starling.’ she joked. ‘So you don’t know?’ the starling asked again, and mother just shook

her head. The starling whipped its tendrils around in sadness and marched in the opposite direction to mother, despite her calling after them. She told me that she went back to look for that starling every day for the next week, but couldn’t find a trace of the living mountain, but last I checked, she thinks they’re still out there, looking for their purpose. The end.”

“Wait wait, that’s the end? Olivon protested. “So mother wasn’t able to help, and it’s just out there now?”

“That makes me feel sad.” Mehandra offered. “What was the point of that story Perm?”

“The point, little ones.” Permea looked out into the Mesa beyond, a flash of light illuminating the mountainous horizon. “The point is honesty. Sometimes stories are just sad.” Permea turned back at her two siblings with tearful eyes and real, generous love.

“But don’t sad stories deserve to be told too?”

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 8 ▶ Go to 8-9.

Tiles: 2x Pod Traps

Victory Condition



Escort Hra to space.

Round limit: 7

Loss Conditions



Lose if Hra is slain.

Challenges



- 1 During the **End Phase** of each round, trigger each pod trap, removing them from the map and roll the Xulc dice, spawning the result in the space the trap was in.
- 2 Xulc ignore the effects of all non-class ether fields.
- 3 When a Rover unit slays an **Infected** adversary, all Rover units within 1 of that adversary suffer 2.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter a jagged bones space suffer 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within 1 of this object recover 1.



Units within 1 of this object gain +1 to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Hra

Check your core box campaign sheet, If you have the milestone “**Intervened in an Ambush**” marked, read the following:

You follow the directions Silky provided you on the search of that magnificent starling Hra. How did Silky know? Just how many tabs was the zusag keeping on your former allies? Not that you're complaining, of course. When you encountered Hra they were a powerful, although somewhat errant starling. Positively bursting with ether energy. You find them stationary at the top of a rocky outcrop, staring at the vegetation below.

*“Rovers,” Hra grinds the sound out of their earthen body. “Disease below. Parasite.” **Evolution.** They don't turn to acknowledge you, but you join them by their side and stare below. Xulc pods smatter across the landscape, and the silvan ashemak and dekaha appear wilted, as diseased as the therans you've come across so far. They also appear to be... moving. “Making others...husks.”*

One of Hra's vine-tendrils gestures to the other side of the valley beneath. A single crystal - a starling shard - atop a tree-stump shrine. “Retrieve with Hra.” Before you can answer, the starling begins its land-slide down the outcrop into the infected silvan below. Time to follow.

Hra is a character ally to Rovers. For this encounter Hra will only use their “Marl” side and will not flip

Otherwise:

Silky's map points you towards the mountains to the east

Ought Never to Sprout

of the Unsouled Barrens, and before long you find yourself close to the mark. This 'Hra' is not hard to find, and nor do they try to hide themselves. A huge four legged starling of earth ether stands atop a ledge with a proud, almost theran like dominion of their environment. You call the name Hra, and their tendrils flutter, scattering leaves and moss, though they do not turn. "The zusag said you would come". Hra's voice is like a distant earthquake. By zusag you assume they mean Silky, but exactly how he managed to inform the starling is a mystery. Another mystery, to be specific. "Disease here, Rovers. Silvans controlled by... others. Dark things. Beautiful things. Against the laws of ether." You move to the side of the starling and see a slow shuffle of shapes below, things that shouldn't walk are walking, things that shouldn't flower are flowering. "Help Hra retrieve something. Then, future." The immense starling begins their descent down into the wilderness below before waiting to see if you would follow.

Hra is a part of their own faction, Hra, which is allied with Rovers, enemies with adversaries, and gains priority before the Rover faction.

Hra has 10 ♥ and the trait: All ➡ and ⬅ effects targeting Hra are reduced by 1.

Hra follows all the adversary logic rules found in the rule book. During their turn, Hra performs the following ability:

 1

Ignore all movement penalties.

— • —

  1  3

 2

Hra requires coxing to get to safety. When Hra's turn starts, if there is a Rover within  1 of them, they perform the following ability instead:

 3

Ignore all movement penalties.

— • —

  1



 self and all allies moved through

With Rovers controlling the ability.

Codex Links

 12

When Hra ends the round occupying the  space, read "Let's Move Big Guy",  8.



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Ought Never to Sprout

Introduction

“Let’s not have a repeat of last night please, little ones.” Permea offered the warning gently as she pulled the blanket over her younger siblings, but the warning held no water. She knew how hard it was for them as it came upon the anniversary of their mothers passing. She knew because she felt it too.

“Come on Perrrrm.” Olivon made sure to draw out his big sister’s name. “One more story.”

“Yeah! Come on Perrrrm” Mehandra echoed her twin.

Permea was tired. It had been a long day at the market, and all she wanted was her own space to rest and escape. Looking at the two babes, both barely 9 summers old, she heard her mothers voice and agreed.

“Ok, my flowers. One more. Did mother ever tell you the story of the living mountain?”

The twins shook their heads in unison, bringing the blanket up to place it gently on their lips for comfort.

“One day, she was out Roving. A clan of tihfur reported a thunderous noise in the night that kept many of them up, and thinking it was the King of Storms, were afraid to investigate themselves.

Mother searched for the source of the noise until she found it; a hulking great starling of the most potent Earth ether, stone and granite and mud and moss, stomping the ground in distress. They were a quadruped - that means they had four legs, like an arkenyn or a grovetender, with a taaaaall neck like a galeaper.

‘Hello!’ mother shouted, ‘Are you ok? Do you need help?’ But you see, this starling wasn’t like others - it hadn’t grown amongst other folk and so didn’t really know what to make of it.”

Permea did her best low, grumbly voice. “‘Yes’, the starling responded. ‘Can you tell me why I’m here? What my purpose is?’

Now, mother had not a clue how to respond. ‘I’ll let you know when I figure that out for myself, starling.’ she joked. ‘So you don’t know?’ the starling asked again, and mother just shook

her head. The starling whipped its tendrils around in sadness and marched in the opposite direction to mother, despite her calling after them. She told me that she went back to look for that starling every day for the next week, but couldn’t find a trace of the living mountain, but last I checked, she thinks they’re still out there, looking for their purpose. The end.”

“Wait wait, that’s the end? Olivon protested. “So mother wasn’t able to help, and it’s just out there now?”

“That makes me feel sad.” Mehandra offered. “What was the point of that story Perm?”

“The point, little ones.” Permea looked out into the Mesa beyond, a flash of light illuminating the mountainous horizon. “The point is honesty. Sometimes stories are just sad.” Permea turned back at her two siblings with tearful eyes and real, generous love.

“But don’t sad stories deserve to be told too?”

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 8 ▶ Go to 8-9.

Tiles: 2x Pod Traps

Victory Condition



Escort Hra to space.

Round limit: 6 ⌚

Loss Conditions



Lose if Hra is slain.

Challenges



- 1 During the **End Phase** of each round, trigger each pod trap, removing them from the map and roll the Xulc dice, spawning the result in the space the trap was in.
- 2 Xulc can not trigger and ignore the effects of all non-class ether fields.
- 3 When a Rover unit slays an **Infected** adversary, all Rover units within ↗ 1 of that adversary suffer ⚡ 2.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter a jagged bones space suffer ⚡ 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within ↗ 1 of this object recover ♡ 1.



It costs units 1 additional movement point to enter a space within ↗ 1 of this object.

Special Rules



Hra

Check your core box campaign sheet, If you have the milestone “**Intervened in an Ambush**” marked, read the following:

You follow the directions Silky provided you on the search of that magnificent starling Hra. As your infection - gift submit - spreads, you take familiar comfort in having Mo, Makaal, and Grandpaw with you once again. “What’s the deal with this guy again,” Makaal asks? “Not a guy, Makaal. A starling. Gender is a concept most unnecessary to our kind,” Mo corrects.

“Sure. I once knew a starling that insisted I call her “her” though. Just saying.”

“Good for her,” Mo responds without a hint of irony, fixing the claw grip on a coalyst ring. Their regular banter continues to be a good distraction from the surging adrenaline in your body. Doesn’t it feel good? When you last came across Hra they were a powerful, although somewhat errant starling. Positively bursting with ether energy.

Grandpaw brings his head low and smells the ground, catching the xulc-pang moments before you do. You move to the top of a rocky outcrop and look below to what you can imagine was once a verdant valley, and there you see them.

Hra bucks and smashes Xulc pods into smithereens across the landscape, and the silvan ashemak and dekaha appear wilted, as diseased as the therans you’ve come across so far. They also appear to be... moving.

Hra appears to be moving toward a small tree stump on

Ought Never to Sprout

the far side of the valley, but they are wounded amidst the mutated silvan onslaught. You kick off the outcrop to the starlings aid.

Hra is a character ally to Rovers. For this encounter Hra will only use their “Marl” side and will not flip. Hra is injured and starts the encounter with only 5 current ♥.

Otherwise:

Silky’s map points you towards the mountains to the east of the Unsouled Barrens, and before long you find yourself close to the mark. Grandpaw barks low in the direction of a secluded valley a short descent from the point you arrive. This ‘Hra’ is not hard to find, and nor do they try to hide themselves. A huge four legged starling of earthen ether stands wrestling with a swarm of violent, infected silvans. “The xulc can infect silvans too,” Mo asks.

“I guess so, and I guess that’s our starling.” Makaal responds. You descend to the bottom of the outcrop to Hra’s aide. Broken and clearly wounded by the monstrous silvans, Hra bellows at your arrival: “The zusag said you would come. You’re late” Hra’s voice is like a distant earthquake. Probably best not to keep this walking mountain waiting any longer than necessary.

Hra is a part of their own faction, Hra, which is allied with Rovers, enemies with adversaries, and gains priority before the Rover faction.

Hra is injured, they have 10 maximum ♥ but only 5 current ♥. They also have the trait: All ➡ and ⬅ effects targeting Hra are reduced by 1.

Hra follows all the adversary logic rules found on page 46 in the rule book. During their turn, Hra performs the following ability:



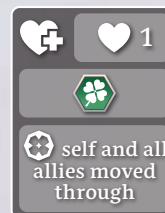
Ignore all movement penalties.



Hra requires coxing to get to safety. When Hra’s turn starts, if there is a Rover within ↗ 1 of them, they perform the following ability instead:



Ignore all movement penalties.



With Rovers controlling the ability.

Codex Links



When Hra ends the round occupying the ↗ space, read “Purpose”, 🔍 8.



Knowable Only by Analogy

Introduction

The entoman's wings twitched as it injected its proboscis into the silvan's ovary. Paralysing saliva trickles out from the entoman's inner glands, down the long, barbed mouthpiece and out into the phloem, deadening the silvan's senses before it has a chance to react. After the entoman had secured its meal, it clicked a hydraulic chitin lever in its mouthpiece and expelled residual air, creating a tight vacuum and drawing in the silvan's minerals into its stomach.

The briarwog watched the entoman fall into its feeding-daze, and let out the long elastic muscle in its mouth. The tongue fired out and unrolled like a coiled whip, wet adhesive mucus crushing the entoman's frail body into the silvan it was eating, before pulling it into the briarwog's mouth. Thin carapace cracked and split under the tension of the theran's lips, spilling the silvan meal it was consuming out of its leaking body. With a neutral, asynchronous blink, the briarwog felt but a moment of satisfaction as the tiny life dissolved in its stomach acid.

And then it felt nothing.

It caught a smell on the wind. Another entoman. The briarwog turned its body slightly, and leapt towards its next meal.

You decide to find a suitable clearing with shelter to set up camp for the night. Hacking through a thick curtain of vines, you are taken aback by how still it is when you see it. Enormous and powerful as they are, hastadilling are uncharacteristically skittish creatures, even to the point where the name is thrown as a playful insult to a soldier that doesn't quite seem to have the mettle for war. But this one stands before you all, its many eyes as wide as they can be. This hastadilling is riddled **sublime** with **ulc**, more than you've seen on any infected creature thus far, even the nidus.

It stands before you, silent, impossibly still, expressionless, staring. Grandpaw whimpers as quiet as he can, and - unmoving - the infested hastadilling lets out a horrible sound. It sounds like the beast is trying to kill itself with its own scream, a rising cacophony of phlegm and chunked vocal chords spitting into the air. The swarm of parasites ripple beneath its skin, seemingly shutting the nerve centre to its brain down, halting the deathhowl. It bounds at you, head lolling from side to side, wings dragging behind, clawed feet tripping over each other. It is chaos and death and **inevitable**.

Only another couple of days of marching before you reach the mountain village of Tuor once again to meet Silky. The pace you've been marching at has been at the precipice of a walk and a run, and you decide you need to rest. Things have been tense amongst you all, there's no doubt about it. The sense that this threat is deeply unfamiliar cannot be shaken, and as the blue-black tint spreads under your flesh, even you are worried - fear **will soon be gone** we feel **no fear and soon neither will you** - about what the future holds for you.

Setup



Take XU-1 ▶ Go to 9 ▶ Go to 10-11.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps

Victory Condition



Slay the Hastadilling.

Round limit: 10

Challenges



- 1 When rolling the damage dice for adversary attacks, increase the result of by +1 .
- 2 Each time a Rover deals 3 or more with an attack, they drain an ether dice in their personal pool, if able to.
- 3 Adversaries ignore the effects of the basic ether fields found in the core rule book.

Terrain



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within 1 of this object recover 1.



It costs units 1 additional movement point to enter a space within 1 of this object.



Units within 1 of this object gain +1 .

Codex Links



14

Immediately after the action where the Hastadilling is defeated, read “Not One, But Two”, 9.



Intermission

Loathsome Changes None Could Explain

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Introduction

There is nothing. Only warm, primordial blackness. No xulc parasites are contained within it. Are you sure?

You awake to an absence of light. Hands, legs immobile. You're sat down, tied up. You make a muffled sound, and daylight overwhelms your senses as the bags over your heads are taken off. Mo backs off quickly to join Makaal and Silky. You're in a place you don't recognize, it appears like an outhouse or a wooden shed. How long have you been out?

Makaal stutters as he talks. "D-dont try anything! There's plenty more of where that came from." He holds a vial of gas in his hand - that explains the knockout.

"There's no need for that, my boy." Silky pipes up with a grave tone.

"You are still yourselves, Rovers?" This isn't so much of a question aimed at you, but at reason itself.

"How do you feel?" Tell them. Tell them how good you feel.

You talk, some of you with new voices, mostly about how much Makaal's toxin hurts your head. Silky seems relieved. Mo edges closer, - stop him - the ether of their body a low burn to your increasingly xulc-infested bodies. "They are themselves, still." Mo offers, Makaal lowers the potion in his hand - thankfully too, because he'd probably knock everyone in the building out if he threw it at this distance.

Silky strokes his antlers. "It appears the amount of etheric magic in your veins is keeping the xulc parasite from being able to take you over, for now at least. Mo and I have designed a tincture to help continue to keep it at bay, - they will try - but it's no permanent fix. No permanent fix.

"As for the rest of Lalos, dear Rovers...." You can tell the zusag is forcing the term, but resolve to accept it in light of the circumstances. "Much of the continent has been affected. Wherever these xulc have come from - beneath, above, between - they've come here fast. In such a short time we've seen them corrupt bless savannah therans, mountainous silvans, and monstrous unsouled alike."

Silky's foot anxiously thumps the ground. "We've seen at least one corrupted ascended humanoid acting as a living birthing chamber, and now we've seen almost the entire contents of a birthing chamber work together to twist and sculpt a powerful creature like a hastadilling like clay. It doesn't matter the environ, it doesn't matter the biology, the xulc appear to be able to pilot, corrupt, reform and hybridize with all manner of life on Lalos - except for the starlings - and you, for now."

Silky sits, letting out a small wince as he does - he's still

weak, it would seem. It hurts to see him like this. We could help.

"We need you, Rovers. Perhaps more than ever. Many communities are keeping this blight at bay, but at this advanced speed, none can sustain their defense in perpetuity. Not unless we learn more. My Eyes and Ears have reported a few leads.

Down towards the Thunder Mesa, a Keb Rasska tribe has been gathering samples of the xulc for study. It appears they had found a way to make use of the unique traits of the xulc to synthesize ointments and boons that are effective against their own kind. Mo is optimistic they can build on this study to aid our quest.

Meanwhile in Taharik, the tihfur have demonstrated a novel resistance to the xulc's infestation. Not like the starlings, who reject the infestation on a physical level, but the tihfur have found a certain spiritual resistance through ritualistic manipulation of morph. If their rituals can be perfected, they may be able to extract the parasite from a living host. It can't happen. It won't.

All the while, our colossal companion Hra out there seems to urge us to go to the Fulgurite Fields post haste. They won't tell us why, they simply say 'to fulfil their purpose'. Whatever that means.

Rest for now, Rovers and decide what you wish to pursue first, for tomorrow, we depart."

The xulc infestation is getting worse as they continue to gain new hosts and spread their territorial control. From now on, when setting up an encounter, use the **B** side of the xulc card.

Open up quest box XU-2 and unpack the standees. These standees will be used for the remainder of the campaign.

Choice



- A** Save the Keb Rasska Tribe. Mo and Makaal believe they can make use of what you gather from there:

Encounter 6 "Mapping Oblivion", 32.

- B** The tihfur are proving resilient to the infection, mostly. Learn from them:

Encounter 7 - "Half in Another World", 38.

- C** Hra appears to want to head to the Fulgurite Fields. Lead on big fella:

Encounter 8 - "Thief of Light, Giver of Light", 46

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Mapping Oblivion

Introduction

The banging on the door won't stop. Each clawed fist bangs in a steady, clockwork rhythm. Akaaka notices how the rhythms aren't symmetrical. Each bangs to its own unique, unrelenting beat, falling in and out of time with each other. The rasska had always appreciated percussion.

Learning the akayan drums was always on her to-do list, when she had more time. When the work was done. When she retired. She pictured herself in a circle with her peers and ancestors, lost in a musical frenzy, swaying in time to the syncopated calls and gutturals of her people's song. She would do so well, she thought. She would impress everyone with the vastness of her soul. She would be one of the rare souls who could stretch across the gamut of science and art and be a paragon of both. If she thought hard enough, she could feel the taut hide beneath her scaled finger-tips as they glanced across the drumskin in slow motion. A voice calls through the drumming in her mind - it was Mirn.

Mirn called her companion rasska's name with her psychic power. With a start, Akaaka turned back to Mirn and the drum-fantasy was ruined.

NO TIME, sent Mirn. THEY'LL BREACH SOON. THE RESEARCH MUST BE SAVED. DISTRACTION? HELP?

Akaaka looked at her companion keb. The two had accomplished so much together, reaching breakthrough after breakthrough on the parasite infestation that had spread across their land in the recent weeks. But the wolves could no longer be held at the gate. Rumor was, one of the fisherfolk brought one back in their recent haul, and then within days, the entire clan was under siege. They had been holed up in their research hovel for the best part of two days now. Not a wink of sleep.

The banging on the door won't stop. Akaaka appreciated a moment when at least three of the fists fell perfectly into sync, and then out again into a disorganized polyrhythm. She was tapping along on the glass bottle of gruv-fat oil in her hand. The door couldn't hold much longer. The hinges were splitting. She thumbs through a pouch on her waist, finding the ether-flint.

"Distraction," agreed Akaaka. She got up.

CONFUSION. WHAT ARE YOU DOING? Mirn sent.

"Distracting," the rasska confirmed. "Got the door?"

Mirn nodded, antennae twitching in uncertainty.

"Thank you for everything. Learn the drums for me."

Akaaka broke the oil-fat vial above her head with one hand, flicked the ether-flint with another, and threw open one of the doors with a third, and pushed past what was once her ilk with the fourth. The last thing Mirn saw as she hurried to grab the door was a spark of fire ether take her life companion, her best friend, in flames. Akaaka was singing the drum-circle song as she grabbed as many of the parasite-hosts as she could with her flaming limbs, and ran until her legs fell beneath her.

Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 10 ▶ Go to 12.

Tiles: 5x Pod Traps, 4x Hoards, 3x Crumbling Columns

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Victory Condition



Collect R **Xulc Samples** and return to a space.

Round limit: 8

Challenges

- 1 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While Rovers carry a **Xulc Sample**, all of their movement actions are reduced by 1.
- 2 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While a Rover carries a **Xulc Sample**, after each of their movement actions, they suffer 1.
- 3 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While a Rover carries a **Xulc Sample**, all adversary attacks that target them gain +1 .

Terrain



Difficult terrain is xulc growth.



Non-flying units that enter fire suffer 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within 1 of this object suffer 1.



Units within 1 of this object gain -1 to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules



Ezmen Clan

Check your core box campaign sheet. If you have either milestone “**Dispatched the Sovereign**” or “**Dispatched the Advocate**” marked, read the following:

Returning to the Ezmen clan for the first time since you slayed their queens, you hoped you'd come across a more comforting scene. From afar you hear the noises of battle and the xulc-stench, and as you arrive the familiar sight of panicked survival. To the east, Keb fights infected rasska, protecting a small series of tents and domiciles. To the west, a horde of infected ashemak surround a barricaded hovel.

ROVERS, a psychic message from a nearby squad of keb warriors rings out.

THE GREAT EMANCIPATORS. MIRN INFORMED US OF YOUR RETURN TO US. WEST SIDE HAS VALUABLE RESEARCH. TAKE THAT, THEN AID IN THE EAST.

WE ASSIST. WE PROTECT - another keb's psychic voice enters your consciousness. Without waiting for a response, the keb launch to your side, some clinging to your backs, all wielding shields. It feels wrong to use these ilk as living armor, but you always admired how readily the Keb Rasska would live and die for each other.

Rovers gain 2. The first time a Rover suffers any amount of damage, this is lost.

Otherwise:

You follow the smell. You've gotten good at following the smell. It's never exactly a welcome smell, but you've gotten good at knowing what it means and following it. Arriving at the desecrated Keb Rasska camp, you see a horde of infected ashemak feasting on the corpses of keb and rasska alike. To the west, you see what looks like a barricaded domicile,

Mapping Oblivion



covered in xulc-infected therans. “That’s the research warren.” Silky offers. “It looks like it’s held up well enough. Retrieve whatever you can from it and let’s be rid of this place!”

I Think It’s Moving

The hoard tiles represent live but otherwise inert xulc samples.

To gain the samples, a Rover has to end their turn on a hoard tile. When they do, place the hoard tile on their class board. Once you have collected R samples, return to a  space. There’s no reward for collecting more than R samples.

Xulc Colony

The Xulc are subsuming the land and its people, rapidly. There are six ether icons by the Keb Rasska tents. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



At the end of the round where all Rovers and Hra are standing on a  and you have R samples, read “**I Hope This Was Worth It**”,  10.



Mapping Oblivion

Introduction

The banging on the door won't stop. Each clawed fist bangs in a steady, clockwork rhythm. Akaaka notices how the rhythms aren't symmetrical. Each bangs to its own unique, unrelenting beat, falling in and out of time with each other. The rasska had always appreciated percussion.

Learning the akayan drums was always on her to-do list, when she had more time. When the work was done. When she retired. She pictured herself in a circle with her peers and ancestors, lost in a musical frenzy, swaying in time to the syncopated calls and gutturals of her people's song. She would do so well, she thought. She would impress everyone with the vastness of her soul. She would be one of the rare few souls who could stretch across the gamut of science and art and be a paragon of both. If she thought hard enough, she could feel the taut hide beneath her scaled finger-tips as they glanced across the drumskin in slow motion. A voice calls through the drumming in her mind - it was Mirn.

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The banging on the door won't stop. Akaaka appreciated a moment when at least three of the fists fell perfectly into sync, and then out again into a disorganized polyrhythm. She was tapping along on the glass bottle of gruv-fat oil in her hand. The door couldn't hold much longer. The hinges were splitting. She thumbed through a pouch on her waist, finding the ether-flint.

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"Thank you for everything. Learn the drums for me."

Akaaka broke the oil-fat vial above her head with one hand, flicked the ether-flint with another, and threw open one of the doors with a third, and pushed past what was once her ilk with the fourth. The last thing Mirn saw as she hurried to grab the door was a spark of fire ether take her life companion, her best friend, in flames. Akaaka was singing the drum-circle song as she grabbed as many of the parasite-hosts as she could with her flaming limbs, and ran until her legs fell beneath her.

Smoke penetrates the sky above the dunes. Between the smell of burning flesh, the distant claps of thunder, and the mountainous power of Hra's newly empowered steps shaking the sand deep beneath your feet, it wouldn't feel like hyperbole to describe this as the end times. **But it's just the beginning, Rovers. It's our beginning. We're so close now, you don't have to fight anymore.**

Surmounting the dune to what once was the Keb Rasska camp, grafted rasska eat the keb remains. All that is left is a barricaded domicile to the west, holes eaten into the walls by infested ashemak. "That's the research warren." Silky offers. "Let us see what you can bring back from there to help us on this last push, Rovers. We're so close now."

We're so close now.

Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 11 ▶ Go to 14-15.

Tiles: 5x Pod Traps, 4x Hoards, 3x Crumbling Columns

Victory Condition



Collect R Xulc Samples and return to a space.

Round limit: 8

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Challenges

- 1 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While Rovers carry a **Xulc Sample**, all of their movement actions are reduced by 1.
- 2 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While a Rover carries a **Xulc Sample**, after each of their movement actions, they suffer ⚡ 1.
- 3 A Rover can only carry one **Xulc Sample**. While a Rover carries a **Xulc Sample**, all adversary attacks that target them gain +1 ⚡.

Terrain



Difficult terrain is xulc growth.



Non-flying units that enter fire suffer ⚡ 2.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Units that end their turn within ↗ 1 of this object suffer ⚡ 1.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain -1 ⚡ to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Special Rules

Ezmen Clan

You follow the smell. You've gotten good at following the smell. It's never exactly a welcome smell, but you've gotten good at knowing what it means and following it. Arriving



at the desecrated Keb Rasska camp, you see a horde of infected ashemak feasting on the corpses of keb and rasska alike. To the west, you see what looks like a barricaded domicile, covered in xulc-infected therans. "That's the research warren." Silky offers. "It looks like it's held up well enough. Retrieve whatever you can from it and let's be rid of this place!"

I Think It's Moving

The hoard tiles represent live but otherwise inert xulc samples.

To gain the samples, a Rover has to end their turn on a hoard tile. When they do, place the hoard tile on their class board. Once you have collected R samples, return to a ↗ space. There's no reward for collecting more than R samples.

Xulc Colony

The Xulc are subsuming the land and its people, rapidly. There are six ether icons by the Keb Rasska tents. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



At the end of the round where all Rovers and Hra are standing on a ↗ and you have R samples, read "Recycled Parts", 11.

Half in Another World

Introduction

Keerafah looked down the shaft of their arrow. They'd been perfectly still now since the sun came down, waiting for the perfect shot. Their arms were tired, but they knew their prey was swift and cunning. If the shot wasn't perfect, it would miss and alert the prey, ruining the hunt. Keerafah knows this, because their prey was once their mentor - Hepthat. Alongside around a third of their clan, Hepthat was lost to the parasite, whilst the rest - including Keerafah, had been able to keep the infection at bay.

Their clan, the Urshif, had long been a solitary one. Their haya urged them so. They learn, they grow, and once ready, they depart, living insular lives aside from the raising of a family or for communal worship. It had been years since Keerafah had spoken to Hepthat, but his hunting skills were legendary. Now, infected by the parasite, Hepthat stalked the woods of Taharik in some sickly parody of his hayan aspect, fur slick with secretions, claws hanging loose and hooked, body an enormous wall of knotted, bulbous muscle. At least until Keerafah had found him. Since then, Hepthat had been dormant, slumbering in the shelter of the great tree bough.

This was the best vantage point for the shot. Keerafah was certain, because Hepthat the great Zaghan hunter of the Urshif had taught them. He'd taught how to calculate for wind, how to assess prey behavior, how to account for the minute weight differences in each arrow, but most importantly how to follow one's haya, to fire on instinct, how to use one's hayin. To close the two tihin and view with the hayin, the aspect-sight. To look through the spaces inbetween, where Morph itself conducts through the physical, where even the forest is flowing matter, and to send your shot to pierce through the waves. And that's what Keerafah did. With a snap, a whistle, and a thud - Keerafah made their master proud.

"You walk with Infected." One of the voices from the woods calls. As you crossed the threshold into the forest Taharik, you found yourself surrounded by the unseen sentries of the tihfur. "Yet at least half of you are not. Explain."

Silky clears his throat in an entirely unnecessary way, as if he hadn't been humming for half of the march here.

"You speak with a Fundamentalist of the Mist Clan of Tuor. I, like many of the spiritual leaders of my kind, are searching for ways to cure my people - and Lalos as a whole - of these prickly, persistent parasites."

The fools.

"I heard a rumor that almighty mystics of the Yanshif had promising leads to squash the scourge. Infected as they are, those that accompany me are the Rovers that brought calm to the King of Storms and felled the Eclipse. We come to offer our aid." The zusag puts a hand on his forehead and offers a low bow. You do the same. After a moment of deliberative silence, one of the tihfur lets himself be seen. "Come with us. The Yanshif is not in a position to turn away allies this eve."

"The xulc, as they call themselves, are more than just simple parasites. Parasites exist all across Lalos. These are antithesis to ether itself, born without connection to any ether, without even to the vastness of the hayin." The Yanshif mystic points to the large eye in the center of her forehead. They talk of the ancient heart of tihfur spirituality and biology, the connection to the fabric of morphic reality, that which allows them to take on their theran aspects. "Not only do they lack connection, they actively repel it."

Another mystic - far younger than the elder before you - perhaps even a child - continues. "Though they must still obey the laws of nature. Their possession is of both Crux and Morph, but it is based on morphic principles of mutation. Through our innate bond to the hayin, the Morph that connects us all, our people have been mostly able to repel the infection, or delay it long enough that they, like you Rovers, maintain their soul."

The third mystic speaks - a woman of middle-age, seemingly a perfect blend of the elder woman and the young girl. "It is our belief that by channeling the hayin, reaching out into that Morph-veil, we can disentangle the parasite at the source - pull it out from the root of the host's morphic form. We begin our first ritual at sunset, on our kin from the Urshif." Each of the mystics gesture out of the treetop pagoda to a group of infected tihfur in the centre of a stone circle.

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“It will attract the xulc, we are sure of it.” The elder mystic warns. “Aid us in protecting the ritual, and we will share our findings with you.”

This is the most hope you have felt since this whole

Setup

Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 12 ▶ Go to 16.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps, 2x Bursting Bells

Victory Condition

Survive for 7 rounds.

Round limit: 7 ⌚

Loss Conditions

Lose if any Tihfur Mystic is slain.

Challenges

- 1 For **Protect the Ritual**, only roll the ether dice R times.
- 2 Set the **Tihfur Mystics** current ❤️ to 4.
- 3 Xulc will always attack **Tihfur Mystics** if they are within range of their attacks.

Terrain



Difficult terrain is xulc growth.



Non-flying units that enter thick bramble suffer ⚡ 2.



Units that trigger a bursting bell trap suffer ⚡ 3.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



Units that end their turn within ↗ 1 of this object recover ❤️ 1.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1 🛡️.

Special Rules

The Left and Right of the Yanshif

Check your core box campaign sheet, If you have the milestone “**Subdued the Ahma**” marked, read the following:

Heading down to the site of the ritual, you see an extremely welcome face. Zeepurah, in full Yanshif Dominant regalia, leaves her husband for a moment, walking to you flanked by their strigiform guards. Zeepurah bows, and extends a hand.

Half in Another World

Even despite your obvious mutation, she grasps each of your hands with warmth and sincerity. “We are blessed this day, dear Yanshif. We have heroes in our midst.”

Each Rover may generate one  dice.

Otherwise:

Even beneath the panicked focus of the current crisis, you can tell the Yanshif hold a deeper tension compared to your last visit here. Though it is undeniable that the defeat of the Ahma has allowed the community to heal, the Yanshif are still in mourning for the loss of their leadership. A small sculpture has appeared in the centre of the village, a mourning-craft, in the likeness of one you once knew - Zeepurah.

The Yanshif

The Yanshif are helping the Urshif reject the xulc from their form. Protect the ritual until it is complete.

There are three Yanshif present (use Nahadir standees). They have 8 ♥ each, are enemies to adversaries, and allies to Rovers. They are consumed by their ritual and are unable to assist in their defense any other way.

Protect the Ritual

You have time to prepare for the assault. At the beginning of the encounter, roll an ether dice R*2 times. Each time you roll the dice, place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll anywhere on the map you wish too. Any one Rover may count as placing any of the ether fields. This can be useful if your Rover gains benefits for placing class specific ether fields.

Xulc Colony

The Xulc are subsuming the land and its people, rapidly.
There are six ether icons on the edges of the map. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



At the end of round 7, read “Did it Work?”,





Half in Another World

Introduction

Keerafah looked down the shaft of their arrow. They'd been perfectly still now since the sun came down, waiting for the perfect shot. Their arms were tired, but they knew their prey was swift and cunning. If the shot wasn't perfect, it would miss and alert the prey, ruining the hunt. Keerafah knows this, because their prey was once their mentor - Hepthat. Alongside around a third of their clan, Hepthat was lost to the parasite, whilst the rest - including Keerafah, had been able to keep the infection at bay.

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Silky clears his throat in an entirely unnecessary way, as

if he hadn't been humming for half of the march here.

"You speak with a Fundamentalist of the Mist Clan of Tuor. I, like many of the spiritual leaders of my kind, are searching for ways to cure my people - and Lalos as a whole - of these prickly, persistent parasites."

The fools.

"I heard a rumor that almighty mystics of the Yanshif had promising leads to squash the scourge. Infected as they are, those that accompany me are the Rovers that brought calm to the King of Storms and felled the Eclipse. We come to offer our aid."

"How could you aid us? We are on our hindlegs here, zusag. We must be certain you will help, for we cannot contend with further enemies in the wilds this eve." The tihfur responds.

Makaal holds the bag of xulc-craft he and Mo had been working on. "We bring research. Technologies to create weapons and resources out of the xulc."

Hra lets the fulgurations within their body ripple outwards. "Power", they speak with the voice of a thunderstorm.

Silky runs his claw through his fur. "Allies with weapons, Yanshif. Not an offer to be taken lightly in these times."

You follow the tihfur to the heart of the Taharik forest, up into the top floor of a treehouse pagoda.

"The xulc, as they call themselves, are more than just simple parasites. Parasites exist all across Lalos. These are antithesis to ether itself, born without connection to any ether, without even to the vastness of the hayin." The Yanshif mystic points to the large eye in the center of her forehead. They talk of the ancient heart of tihfur spirituality and biology, the connection to the fabric of morphic reality, that which allows them to take on their theran aspects. "Not only do they lack connection, they actively repel it."

Another mystic - far younger than the elder before you - perhaps even a child - continues. "Though they must still obey the laws of nature. Their possession is of both

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Crux and Morph, but it is based on morphic principles of mutation. Through our innate bond to the hayin, the Morph that connects us all, our people have been mostly able to repel the infection, or delay it long enough that they, like you Rovers, maintain their soul.”

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“It will attract the xulc, we are sure of it.” The elder mystic warns. “Aid us in protecting the ritual, and we will share our findings with you.”

This is the most hope you have felt since this whole thing began. So why are you so afraid?

Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 13 ▶ Go to 18-19.

Tiles: 4x Pod Traps, 2x Bursting Bells

Victory Condition



Survive for 7 rounds.

Round limit: 7

Loss Conditions



Lose if any Tihfur Mystic is slain.

Challenges

- 1 Ignore the **Protect the Ritual** special rule. You don’t get to place any ether fields.
- 2 Set the **Tihfur Mystics** current ♥ to 4.
- 3 Xulc will always attack **Tihfur Mystics** if they are within range of their attacks.

Terrain



Difficult terrain is xulc growth.



Non-flying units that enter thick bramble suffer ★ 2.



Units that trigger a bursting bell trap suffer ★ 3.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ★ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



Units that end their turn within ↗ 1 of this object recover ♥ 1.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1.

Half in Another World

Special Rules

The Left and Right of the Yanshif

Check your core box campaign sheet, If you have the milestone “**Subdued the Ahma**” marked, read the following:

Heading down to the site of the ritual, you see an extremely welcome face. Zeepurah, in full Yanshif Dominant regalia, leaves her husband for a moment, walking to you flanked by their strigiform guards. Zeepurah bows, and extends a hand. Even despite your obvious mutation, she grasps each of your hands with warmth and sincerity. “We are blessed this day, dear Yanshif. We have heroes in our midst.”

Each Rover may generate one  dice.

Otherwise:

Even beneath the panicked focus of the current crisis, you can tell the Yanshif hold a deeper tension compared to your last visit here. Though it is undeniable that the defeat of the Ahma has allowed the community to heal, the Yanshif are still in mourning for the loss of their leadership. A small sculpture has appeared in the centre of the village, a mourning-craft, in the likeness of one you once knew - Zeepurah.

The Yanshif

The Yanshif are helping the Urshif reject the xulc from their form. Protect the ritual until it is complete.

There are three Yanshif present (use Nahadir standees). They have 8 ❤️ each, are enemies to adversaries, and allies to Rovers. They are consumed by their ritual and are unable to assist in their defense any other way.

Protect the Ritual

You have time to prepare for the assault. At the beginning of the encounter, roll an ether dice R times. Each time you roll the dice, place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll anywhere on the map you wish too. Any one Rover may count as placing any of the ether fields. This can be useful if your Rover gains benefits for placing specific ether fields.

Xulc Colony

The Xulc are subsuming the land and its people, rapidly. There are six ether icons on the edges of the map. These icons represent possible spawn locations throughout the encounter.

When an adversary with the **Infected** trait is slain, place it off to the side of the map on its side. During the **Start Phase**, for each adversary that is both off to the side and flipped vertically, roll an ether dice from the general pool, then spawn that adversary at the space with the ether icon corresponding to the result of the roll. Then, for each adversary that is both off to the side and placed on its side, flip them vertically.

Codex Links



At the end of round 7, read “**No Sky Could Blind You Now**”,  12.



Thief of Light, Giver of Light

Introduction

Once, when the land had many names, a clan travelled, for travelling was what the clan did best. They moved by cart and by carriage at the behest of their king, a wise and beloved man, who asked of his people but one task - find the place with the "most life". The clan marched to the endless bogs of the far east and lived amongst the wilds, learning to live amongst the briarwog and march atop stilts. After a year the king, thus far silent atop his palanquin, said "no". And so the clan travelled on.

The clan formed a budding metropolis and lived with other clans, forming complex trade and building meaningful connections. After six months the king, thus far hidden inside his throne room, said "no". And so the clan travelled on.

The clan moved to the south west of the arid desert in search of a vibrant oasis where they could grow trees and swim forever. As the clan travelled - for travelling was what the clan did best, they were beset by a powerful thunderstorm, with the most devastating lightning any of them had ever seen. Forks of lightning the size of the Azoth itself exploded across the path ahead. Thinking they must find another way, the clan set about face, but the king left his carriage and pointed up to the lightning.

"There. That is where I want to go. Take me there." His advisors advised, his warriors worried, but the king was adamant. The clan, afraid to disappoint their beloved king but left with no other choice, refused. And so the king travelled on.

The clan watched as their king travelled into the storm, for travelling was what the king did best. Before he was out of sight, the clan saw the king climb the largest rock any of them could see. His elder bones unscuppered by weariness, the silhouette of the king soon found its way to the top. The last the clan heard before the lightning struck the king into ether was the loud echo of one word, "yes".

- The Old King of Storms, Anonymous

Hra hasn't spoken many words since you set off to follow them. The fact that you notice this is remarkable in and of itself, because the starling is far from conversational at

the best of times. But your giant ally appears determined to make it to the Fulgurite Fields. **An awful place. You think you can escape us there?** Mo and Makaal seem back at home in the Thunder Mesa, but Silky appears distracted. It's highly uncommon to see the zusag without his Aeiros, but thus far his journey has been consumed by the conjuration and subsequent dismissal of other constructs too. Vertexes, Hyperbola, even lesser seen Labryrites come and go.

"Call it practice, dear Rovers," Silky explained, making use of the Crux at crescendo." It's true, you could feel the potency of Crux swell as you approached the Fulgurite Fields. **Turn back.** You and your fellow Rovers feel the gentle twinge of the parasites within you threaten you, but are sure to hide it from your companies. Lightning storms strike with a ferocity and tempo that you haven't seen since you confronted Uzem.

"Or distraction," Makaal couldn't help but throw in a jibe.

"And what would be so wrong with distraction, young folk? The world is dying. An insidious enemy, beyond reason or conversation, infiltrates the fabric of our reality in the name of greed, manipulation and selfishness. A little creative distraction without shame feels warranted, no?" Greed? **Do you not see all that we offer?**

Makaal has a tear in his eye. Mo puts a hand on their merchant allies shoulder and flutters their tendrils in a harmony of humor and deep empathy. It's good to be reminded of the zusag's wisdom from time to time.

"We're here," Hra announces. Of all the places that 'here' could be, it appears to be a maelstrom of wild etheric energy across giant lodestones, each struck by lightning. You would have preferred 'here' to be many other places. "Protect me as I empower myself," Hra commands as they walk into the tumult of the lodestones.

"From who," Makaal asks. "Yourself?"

"No," Hra answers, still walking, "them". Their vine tendrils point out to the surrounding ambush of infected tihfur and rasska in the distance the way you came. Had they been trailing us?

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Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 14 ▶ Go to 20.

Tiles: 3x Magical Traps

Victory Condition



Empower Hra three times.

Round limit: 8

Loss Conditions



Lose if Hra is slain.

Challenges

- 1 When Rovers wish to ignore Fulgurite Fields, they must spend an additional +2 ether dice.
- 2 The damage Rover units suffer from Fulgurite Fields is increased by +1 .
- 3 Xulc will always attack Hra if they are within range of their attacks.

Special Rules



Fulgurite Fields

There are 6 crystals around the map, each with an ether icon. At the beginning of each round, roll an ether dice from the general pool and place that dice onto the space of the crystal with the ether icon that matches the result of the roll.

At the end of each round, all units within 0-1 of the crystal with an ether dice on it suffers 3, then return this ether dice to the general pool.

Rovers can ignore this roll. At the end of the round,



Rovers as a group may return R ether dice from their personal pools to the general pool to choose which fulgurite crystal is struck instead.

Suffuse With Ether

Hra has sought out the Fulgurite Fields of the Thunder Mesa. Protect them as they absorb the raw ether.

Hra must be struck by the Fulgurite Fields rule three times, once at the crystal, once at the crystal, and once at the crystal.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter jagged crystals suffer 2.



Units that trigger a magic trap suffer 3. When a magic trap is triggered, roll an ether dice and place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll in the space the trap was in. A result of or places an adversary or , respectively.



Units within 1 of this object gain +1 .



Units within 1 of this object gain +1 to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Codex Links



23

Immediately after completing the requirements of Suffuse With Ether, read “You’re Glowing”, 13.

Thief of Light, Giver of Light

Introduction

Once, when the land had many names, a clan travelled, for travelling was what the clan did best. They moved by cart and by carriage at the behest of their king, a wise and beloved man, who asked of his people but one task - find the place with the "most life". The clan marched to the endless bogs of the far east and lived amongst the wilds, learning to live amongst the briarwog and march atop stilts. After a year the king, thus far silent atop his palanquin, said "no". And so the clan travelled on.

The clan formed a budding metropolis and lived with other clans, forming complex trade and building meaningful connections. After six months the king, thus far hidden inside his throne room, said "no". And so the clan travelled on.

The clan moved to the south west of the arid desert in search of a vibrant oasis where they could grow trees and swim forever. As the clan travelled - for travelling was what the clan did best, they were beset by a powerful thunderstorm, with the most devastating lightning any of them had ever seen. Forks of lightning the size of the Azoth itself exploded across the path ahead. Thinking they must find another way, the clan set about face, but the king left his carriage and pointed up to the lightning.

"There. That is where I want to go. Take me there." His advisors advised, his warriors worried, but the king was adamant. The clan, afraid to disappoint their beloved king but left with no other choice, refused. And so the king travelled on.

The clan watched as their king travelled into the storm, for travelling was what the king did best. Before he was out of sight, the clan saw the king climb the largest rock any of them could see. His elder bones unscuppered by weariness, the silhouette of the king soon found its way to the top. The last the clan heard before the lightning struck the king into ether was the loud echo of one word, "yes".

- The Old King of Storms, Anonymous

the best of times. But your giant ally appears determined to make it to the Fulgurite Fields. **An awful place. You think you can escape us there?**

In fact, if you pay attention, everyone is mostly quiet. Mo and Makaal tinker with the research yielded from the Keb Rasska camp, weaving xulc neural networks into patterned jewels, sewing belt-loops to inflation sacs. Grandpaw seems to always have an eye on you since the xulc asserted it's dominance after the tihfur ritual. **Smart beast. It is unwise to take one's eyes from a predator.** Silky has been practicing his conjuration and subsequent dismissal of myriad constructs far beyond his usual Aeiros companion. Vertexes, Hyperbola, even lesser seen Labryrites come and go.

"Call it practice, dear Rovers," Silky explained. Making use of the Crux at crescendo. It's true, you could feel the potency of Crux swell as you approached the Fulgurite Fields. **Turn back. NOW.** It happened again. You said part of this aloud. Grandpaw lowers his head and lets out a threatening growl. Mo and Makaal grip the hilts of their carving tools, and Silky's current construct tessellates into a sharper form. You apologise. Hra never stops moving.

"We're here," Hra announces. Of all the places that 'here' could be, it appears to be a maelstrom of wild etheric energy across giant lodestones, each struck by lightning. You would have preferred 'here' to be many other places. "Protect me as I empower myself," Hra commands as they walk into the tumult of the lodestones.

"From who," Makaal asks. "Yourself?"

"No," Hra answers, still walking. "Them". Their vine tendrils point out a monstrous sight. **Beautiful.** A crown, of all things, now infested and possessed by the xulc. **A fitting title for what is to come.** What could the xulc achieve with such a power? **You'll see.**

Hra hasn't spoken many words since you set off to follow them. The fact that you notice this is remarkable in and of itself, because the starling is far from conversational at

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Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 15 ▶ Go to 22-23.

Tiles: 3x Magical Traps

Victory Condition



Empower Hra three times.

Round limit: 8 ⌚

Loss Conditions



Lose if Hra is slain.

Challenges

- 1 When Rovers wish to ignore Fulgurite Fields, they must spend an additional +2 ether dice.
- 2 The damage Rover units suffer from Fulgurite Fields is increased by +1 ⚡.
- 3 Xulc will always attack Hra if they are within range of their attacks.

Special Rules



Fulgurite Fields

There are 6 crystals around the map, each with an ether icon. At the beginning of each round, roll an ether dice from the general pool and place that dice onto the space of the crystal with the ether icon that matches the result of the roll.

At the end of each round, all units within ↗ 0-1 of the crystal with an ether dice on it suffers ⚡3, then return this ether dice to the general pool.



Rovers can ignore this roll. At the end of the round, Rovers as a group may return R+2 ether dice from their personal pools to the general pool to choose which fulgurite crystal is struck instead.

Suffuse With Ether

Hra has sought out the Fulgurite Fields of the Thunder Mesa. Protect them as they absorb the raw ether.

Hra must be struck by the Fulgurite Fields rule three times, once at the crystal, once at the crystal, and once at crystal.

Terrain



Non-flying units that enter jagged crystals suffer ⚡2.



Units that trigger a magic trap suffer ⚡3. When a magic trap is triggered, roll an ether dice and place the ether field that corresponds with the result of the roll in the space the trap was in. A result of or places an adversary or , respectively.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1 ⛔.



Units within ↗ 1 of this object gain +1 ⚡ to the first attack they perform during their turn.

Codex Links



Immediately after completing the requirements of Suffuse With Ether, read “Apocalypse Conduit”, 14.

Promethean Purpose

Introduction

Transcribed musings from “Silky”, resident Fundamentalist of the Mist clan.

When I was but a young student, I struggled often with the passivity of our study. I thought the querists were too vain, the sophists too navel-gazing, I craved a different, more impactful path. My Fundamentalist at the time saw my strife and sought to sunder it.

“Young Silky”, she said as she took me aside, “Have I ever told you about the Mind School?” I had of course, but only through my unofficial extra-curricular activity in the forbidden part of the libraries, so I simply shook my head. She went on to tell me that the Mind School formed out of a rejection of the other School’s principles, and of the core of their curriculum, a principle known as Antarcanism.

Antarcanism offers an origin myth, how reality came to be. For the antarcanist, all that existed was simply a whole, known as the Monum. The Monum was all, and all was the Monum. The Monum absolutely did contain all, even the concept that it didn’t. That concept necessarily caused the Monum to create Something Else outside of itself, an act that began a chain reaction. This Something Else needed rules, because without the wholeness of the Monum, it was chaos. So then, the Something Else began by first crafting a boundary, a reality to perceive itself and an itself to do the perception. A Morph, and a Crux respectively.

Suffice to say, the syzygy of the Something Else got carried away, creating endless amounts of lesser anima until around four stuck - earth, fire, water and wind. The antarcanists believe this whole thing was a mistake, and the rejection of the Minor Arcana is the path to true enlightenment, where one can subsist solely on the Major Anima. Pure Morph and pure Crux, pure body and pure soul. Much of what they did, when not writing of this, was a prolonged period of intense ascetism that mostly just resulted in self-mummification.

It was a strange philosophy. Hard to follow. Probably why the Mind School simply dwindled away. It’s hard to get fresh fur when your registration form is a command to cease existing. Anyway, I think my old teacher was trying to warn me against “getting too involved”. I’m not sure it worked.

“Aren’t you glad I’m here?” Silky asked with an exuberance you haven’t seen in a while. “Without me, who knows what fate could befall our land.” Silky’s... ‘confidence’ feels familiar. In fact, it all feels familiar. Mo, Makaal and Grandpaw in tow, Hra’s tremendous, coruscating form leading the way. The starling - if you can still call them that, claimed to know how to generate enough Etheric energy that the tihfur ritual could work, and was taking the party there. Fool. It can’t work. You’re ours now, we’re one.

You ignore the voice, because for the first time in a long time, you have genuine hope. Hope for what this might be like when it’s all over. You won’t like it.

Perhaps this is just what your life is to be now. Perhaps this was a calling, a reminder from the elements themselves not to part from each other’s company, but to come together. To do good. To change things. Perhaps it’s even greater - perhaps this parasite guest was perfectly designed to unite the disparate clans of Lalos altogether. You don’t know how right you are.

Hra leads you to the Unsouled Barrens. You fight off a few xulc-infested urns and stomaw - far fewer than last you were here, a sign that Ozendyn and his querists have been doing good work. Hra leads you to another clearing. They love doing that.

“Rovers,” Hra turns to you all. “This is where we part ways.” Good.

“What?” Makaal asks.

“I must leave now. It’s my time. Thank you, Rovers. For all you’ve done. For the first time, I have felt true companionship. I have truly been part of a clan.”

You all look at each other bewildered and dumbfounded. Is Hra just going to... leave?

Makaal, in all his wisdom, breaks the silence again. “I don’t get it. Where are you going? You have a tent somewhere in this dunghole?”

“Young one,” crackles Hra with uncharacteristic warmth.

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“I’m going to fulfill my purpose.”

All of the lightning in Hras body charges. Light comes from inside. They are pure, glowing white now, a sun brought low to make communion with the earth.

“Run,” Silky shouts!

RUN.

Setup

Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 16 ▶ Go to 24-25.

Tiles: 3x Pod Traps

Victory Condition

Slay all adversaries.

Round limit: 10 ⌚

Challenges

- 1 All units gain +R*3 ♥.
- 2 When rolling the damage dice for adversary attacks, increase the result of by +1 ⚡.
- 3 Increase the range of the node by +1 ↗.

Special Rules

Expulsion Ritual

You are inside of Hra, fighting the parasite with your “third eye”. Remove Hra’s ally card. In this mindscape, you will have to slay all adversaries. Only then will the parasite be weak enough to be extracted from your body.

Terrain



Units that generate an ether dice while within ↗ 1 of this node generate a dice instead. Rovers can not take this dice.



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer ⚡ 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



Rovers that enter xulc growth suffer ⚡ 1.

Codex Links

🔍 25

After the action where the Hastadilling is slain, read “It’s Not Over”, 15.

Collapse, Greying & Disintegration

Introduction

Deep beneath the world, we eat each other. We must. It's been so long. There is no memory down here. No light. Just the water and the eating. We eat each other down here. That's all there is. That and the water around us. We think there was once other things to eat. It doesn't make sense that we would only eat ourselves. But there is no sense anymore.

There is some memory, though. Deep in our bodies, passed down, from brood to nest. We remember something that put us here, so, so long ago. We remember we had eyes then. We were large. Something put us here, so deep and so dark. And now we swim, we breed, we remember, we eat. We don't sleep. We don't talk. There are no stories, no families. We remember enough, cruelly, to know what those concepts are. But there are none.

Time passes. So much time, more time than there ever was before we were here. We're even smaller now.

The world breaks. Something new. Space above. Scent. A new kind of water. We swim out. Others are here. They're not like us. We're so hungry.

As we eat them, we experience old things. Things from before. Color, scent, feeling. Memory. Their minds, so simple. We eat those instead. When we do, we get to keep the old things. They're ours now. More things come through. Even new things.

More than we ever knew. We know heat now, because there's more than the cold. We know comfort now, because there's more than the dark. We know each other now, because we're more than just food.

There's a whole other life out there.

The campfire flame flickers. Its warmth is comforting, and for the first time since the xulc parasite infested you, you sweat. You forgot how refreshing it is. The little treasures and quirks of the body, once nullified by the creature hijacking your nervous system. The shivers quelled for you all around an hour ago, the hangover of a body readjusting to the shock of sole control.

Mourning has a way of making the air feel strange. Confrontational in its passivity. How dare it so gently

enter your lungs, yet deny this kindness to ones you love so much? They're just over there. It could if it wanted to. But it doesn't. And yet you must. Whom would it serve if you didn't? One big, spiteful expletive at the wind for being so selective? It might feel good for a second, a violent, gritted-teeth second, but that feeling would soon turn to powerlessness when you gasp for your own breath.

So you do breathe the air. You'll make sure not to enjoy it, though.

You're not sure if Hra breathed air anyway, but that's beside the point.

The loss of Hra seems to hit Makaal the most, strangely. You're not sure you saw the two ever really have a conversation on your short but intense journey together. Perhaps he's touched by a being seemingly reaching their apex only to sacrifice themselves. Perhaps it's just the first thing he's lost.

After the xulc left your body and formed something... new, it escaped in the direction of the western shoreline. Grandpaw has been following its trail, but you've had to move slowly as you recover from the sickness that set in soon after you left the shrine of Hra. Mo and Silky have been occupied brewing stamina draughts, which they assure will get you on your feet by the time you close in on the trail in the early morning. Now, to rest.

Morning arrives, the campsite packed up onto Grandpaw's back and your hunt nears its conclusion. Webs of xulc growth starts to appear underfoot, crawling slowly across the stone leading down towards the coast. They grow into thick roots, consuming and absorbing nearby plantlife and silvans into its mass. The roots all converge on a pulsating, embryonic structure embedded within the coastal cliff-face. Inside the transparent sac, you see the xulc-thing that formed from your parasites sleeping. Nesting.

Without the creature inside moving, it seems to notice you. Tendrils spiral out from the pupa, and launch to attack you. Other xulc parasites emerge from the mass of pods.

This is where it ends.

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Setup



Take XU-2 ▶ Go to 17 ▶ Go to 26-27.

Tiles: 3x Pod Traps, 4x Monstrous Growth

Victory Condition



Slay the Prime Xulc.

Round limit: 6

Challenges

- 1 When a Rover suffers damage as part of a Prime Xulc action, they drain an ether dice in their personal pool, then drain an ether dice in their infusion pool.
- 2 The Prime Xulc does not trigger and ignores the effects of the basic ether fields found in the core rule book. When a Rover places a basic ether field into one of the Prime Xulc's spaces, place the same ether field into that Rover's space.
- 3 When a Rover unit rolls the damage dice, they treat a result of as -1 .

Terrain



Units that trigger a pod trap suffer 3. When a pod trap is triggered, roll the xulc dice and spawn the result in the space the trap was in.



Difficult terrain is water.



Difficult terrain is xulc growth.

Special Rules



Round Limit

This is a 3 phase encounter. Each phase has its own round limit.

The Prime Xulc

The Prime Xulc is nested safely within their hive.

They take their turns as normal, but are otherwise immune to all sources of damage and can not be moved for any reason. Root out the hive to expose them to attack.

Phase 1

There are several Nidus Clusters throughout the map. For two Rovers, there are Nidus Clusters at spaces and . For three Rovers there is also a Nidus Cluster at , and for four Rovers there is another Nidus Cluster at . Nidus Clusters are special objects with 30 , they are enemies to Rovers and allies to adversaries. During the **Start Phase** of round 2, and each even round after that, roll the xulc dice once for each Nidus Cluster, and then spawn the result within 1 of that cluster. If the result of the dice is a blank face side, reroll the dice once, keeping the second result.

Codex Links



At the end of the round where all Nidus Clusters have been destroyed, read “**Everything Executioner**”, 16.

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